

NEW TEETH

A Russian woman has baffled dentists by growing three new teeth. The 104-year-old woman lives alone in a remote mountain village, where she grows vegetables and raises poultry. She said she was happy to have the new teeth, as she would now be able to chew her favourite ginger biscuits. People usually have all their teeth by the time they are twenty.

- Why are dentists baffled by the woman growing new teeth?

FACTORY WAGES

The women who worked in the clothing factories of a century ago were paid not by the hour or a fixed wage, but by the number of garments they made. They worked long hours, often in uncomfortable and crowded conditions, with little time off. When they were sick they received no pay. Some women earned more money than others even though they were all doing the same type of work.

- Why could some women earn more in a day than others?

NINJA

Our cat Ninja was beautiful. She was a tortoiseshell cat - she had multi-coloured fur with black, white and orangey-brown markings. She was affectionate towards us, but usually disliked strangers. More than one visitor had left with a scratched hand. Regardless of this behaviour, we thought she was a great pet and we loved her. When she died, we all agreed that we wanted some way to remember her. Naturally, we had lots of photos, but it didn't seem enough. As my mother said, "What if the house burns down and all the photos are gone?"

We went to the garden centre and purposefully chose a small rhododendron tree. When we buried Ninja, we planted it on top of her. In the spring, the tree has beautiful orange flowers with dark specks on them.

- In the story, who do you think is meant by 'we'?
- Why do you think we chose that particular rhododendron?

AS BAD AS IT GETS

I don't believe it. Last week it was 'The Best Day of my Life' and now it's this. Why can't Mr Thoms have more imagination?

Groaning inwardly, Jaz rolled her eyes, and hoped for inspiration.

OK. Let's see now. The day I lost my Barbie doll. I was only seven, but I remember the pain. Or the day I tripped over in front of the whole football team. No, I don't want the entire universe to know about that.

The day old Rexie died was pretty awful. I still miss his great big eyes and waggy tail. He was a lovely dog.

I know! The day Dad lost his job. No, that was his worst day. Anyway, he wasn't out of work long. .

The day I missed out on getting into the national-swimming team by three lousy rotten seconds. They don't come much worse than that.

There's so much to choose from. My life is full of worst days. This one's not so good either. Now I think of it, I've had a terrible life.

Jaz looked over at her friend Elyse, who was adjusting her wheelchair to be closer to the desk. Injuries from a car accident last month meant she would be like this for another six weeks. She watched as Elyse started writing. She wrote without pausing, quickly filling the lines.

Jaz turned back to her own desk, lowered her eyes and started writing: Three days after I turned seven, I took Crystal, my Barbie doll, out on a picnic ...

- What kind of inspiration was Jaz hoping for?
- What did Jaz mean by 'Why can't Mr Thoms have more imagination'?
- What was Elyse most likely writing about?
- Why do you think Elyse was able to write 'without pausing'?
- REACTION QUESTION
- Do you think Jaz had had a terrible life? Why do you say that?